PRODUCTBEACON RESEARCH · WEM RADAR

# California signs its workplace AI bills. A call-scoring specialist is acquired.

## Weekly summary · 3 October 2026

By Yohay Etsion · former NICE product leader (Recording/WFO), 2008–2021 · public sources only · full disclosure on the last slide

THE RULES

# California bans AI that reads workers' emotions, from January.

- The Governor signed all five workplace and chatbot AI bills we track and vetoed none.
- From 1 January 2027, employers may not use AI workplace tools to recognise or predict a person's emotional state.
- The law still allows tools used "to ensure safety." The Governor's signing letter says it "lacks key definitions" and asks lawmakers to refine it.
- From July 2027, an automated score cannot be the only basis for discipline or firing. If it is the main basis, a person must corroborate it.

> Watch: whether vendors rename, limit or remove emotion features. We found none doing so yet.

SOURCES California Legislature, read 3 Oct · Governor of California, 30 Sep · Fisher Phillips, 1 Oct

THE HUMAN

# Large businesses must give California customers a way to reach a human.

- Businesses with over $500 million in revenue may not present a chatbot as human. Every customer-service channel needs a way to ask for a person during business hours.
- They must try in good faith to connect within 15 minutes, or book a callback within one business day.
- Single holds must stay under 15 minutes, and all holds under an hour. The law takes effect on 1 January 2027.
- Layoff notices must also say when AI caused the cuts.

> Why it matters: contact centres serving California need a staffed human queue that meets a legal service level.

SOURCES California Legislature, read 3 Oct · Governor of California, 28 Sep

THE DEALS

# Salesforce agrees to buy Listen Labs. TCN buys a call-scoring specialist.

- Salesforce signed an agreement to buy Listen Labs, which simulates customers for research. It disclosed no price; a reported $2 billion remains unconfirmed.
- Salesforce expects the deal to close between November and January, subject to regulatory clearance.
- TCN bought Abstrakt, which sells live call prompts and automatic call scoring. Terms were not disclosed.
- It is the first purchase of a call-scoring specialist in our coverage.

> Watch: whether Thoma Bravo's Verint makes the small acquisitions Fitch expects.

SOURCES Salesforce, 29 Sep · Business Insider, 9 Sep · TCN, 1 Oct

THE SUITE

# Verint cuts costs while independent vendors pitch its customers.

- Fitch says Verint has made about 85% of a $187 million cost-cutting programme. It expects revenue to fall in fiscal 2027.
- Fitch expects the owner, Thoma Bravo, to favour small acquisitions over paying down debt.
- Verint has still not announced a combined Verint and Calabrio product.
- Level AI and Assembled published a guide to leaving “legacy platforms like Verint or Calabrio.”

> Our view: the merger shows so far in costs and a shared name, not a combined product.

SOURCES Fitch Ratings, 28 Sep · Verint, 29 Sep · Level AI, 28 Sep

THE RESULTS

# AI agents report high resolution rates. Apple reportedly pauses support cuts.

- Genesys reports retailer Riachuelo resolves 84% of WhatsApp customers' needs without an employee, against 30% with its earlier chatbots.
- Salesforce reports Canada Goose's agent resolves 89% of routine messages and 15% of calls on its own. Both are vendor-published figures.
- Bloomberg reports Apple put on hold a plan to cut about 5,000 support staff. Apple kept its AI phone assistant and has not commented.

> Our view: voice still lags messaging badly. Apple paused job cuts without pulling back the AI.

SOURCES Genesys, 30 Sep · Salesforce, 1 Oct · MacRumors, 29 Sep

THE PREDICTIONS

# Our check of the annual report's 18 predictions: 12 supported.

- Our assessment: twelve supported, one showing early signs, one mixed, two weakened, one unchanged and one not triggered.
- Emotion-AI restrictions move from untested to supported, now that California has a law.
- The disproof test is not triggered: no tracked vendor moved from per-resolution pricing back to seats.
- Autonomous scheduling stays weakened: vendors claim only narrow automatic actions.

> These are our assessments, combining this week's developments with earlier evidence.

SOURCES ProductBeacon Research, 3 Oct

SOURCES

# Sources behind this week's news.

Company announcements, official records and reporting:

COMPANY ANNOUNCEMENTS

Salesforce · TCN · Verint · Level AI · Genesys

OFFICIAL SOURCES

California Legislature · Governor of California

ANALYST AND PRESS REPORTING

Fisher Phillips · Business Insider · Fitch Ratings · MacRumors

Source links and detailed citations accompany the full weekly summary.

FULL DISCLOSURE

# California’s new law keeps a human within reach.

California now requires large businesses to keep a person within reach of customers. Vendors report high AI resolution rates on messaging, while voice lags. Workforce plans need a staffed human queue as well as AI.

→ **Read the full report**

productbeacon.agency/research/state-of-wem-2026

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